



Honing skills: The Uganda cricket team poses for a group picture during its two-week tour of Sri Lanka, where it is undergoing training ahead of this year's T20 World Cup. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

TO BOLSTER ITS CAMPAIGN, UGANDA'S CRICKET BODY HIRED FORMER INDIAN FIRST-CLASS CRICKETER ABHAY SHARMA AS HEAD COACH

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

The 2024 men's T20 World Cup, which will comprise 20 teams for the first time, will include nine Associate teams, the most in any edition of the T20 showpiece event so far. Twelve teams got automatic entry, while the eight remaining slots were filled via the ICC's regional qualifiers, comprising the top two teams from Africa, Asia, and Europe, along with one team each from the Americas and the East Asia Pacific groups.

In preparation for its maiden T20 World Cup appearance, Uganda's national team, known as the Cricket Cranes, has embarked on a two-week tour of Sri Lanka. It engaged in friendly matches against Sri Lanka's Emerging and A teams in Galle and also faced off against the Army in Colombo.

To bolster its campaign, Uganda's cricket body hired former Indian first-class cricketer Abhay Sharma as head coach. With an illustrious coaching background spanning India A, India Under-19s, the Indian women's cricket team, and the Delhi Ranji Trophy team, Abhay brings

extensive experience and aims to impart invaluable knowledge to the budding Ugandan squad.

"The Associate members need more game time, and since they don't get opportunities to play with the top teams, it's about handling the pressure and backing your game. That's most important," Abhay told *Sportstar*.

In January this year, the Uganda cricket team went to Saphale in Maharashtra to train at the Omtex ICWC Cricket Institute and played nine practice games. "Since we could not travel to India now due to the IPL and the UK and Australia were